emotions. Jainism denies the existence of God. In its early stages, deity was not worshipped in Jainism. It emphasises that salvation cannot be attained by worshipping god or by sacrifices. It stipulates that one can escape misery only by performing austerities.

Mahavira rejected Vedic authority. Hence, Jainism is an unorthodox religion. According to Jainism, the world has no beginning or end. It goes through a series of progress and decline according to an eternal law. Jainism advocated dualism: the world is made of soul (*jiva*) and matter (*ajiva*), which are eternal. The coming together of *jiva* and *ajiva* creates *karma* (action), which leads to an endless cycle of birth and rebirth. To free oneself from karma, one has to practice severe austerities and self-mortification. Therefore, in Jainism, only monks could achieve liberation from the cycle of birth and rebirth.

Triratnas

Jain discipline requires adherence to certain rigorous rules. The Jains are required to follow three principles called Triratnas or Three Gems.

(1) Right faith (*samyag-darshana*)
(2) Right knowledge (*samyag-jnana*)
(3) Right conduct (*samyag-mahavrata*)

Five Great Vows

The monks have to undertake the five great vows (*pancha-mahavrata*):

(1) Not to kill or injure (*ahimsa*)
(*2*) Not to steal (*asteya*)
(3) Not to lie (*satya*)
(4) Celibacy (*brahmacharya*)
(5) Not to possess property (*aparigraha*)

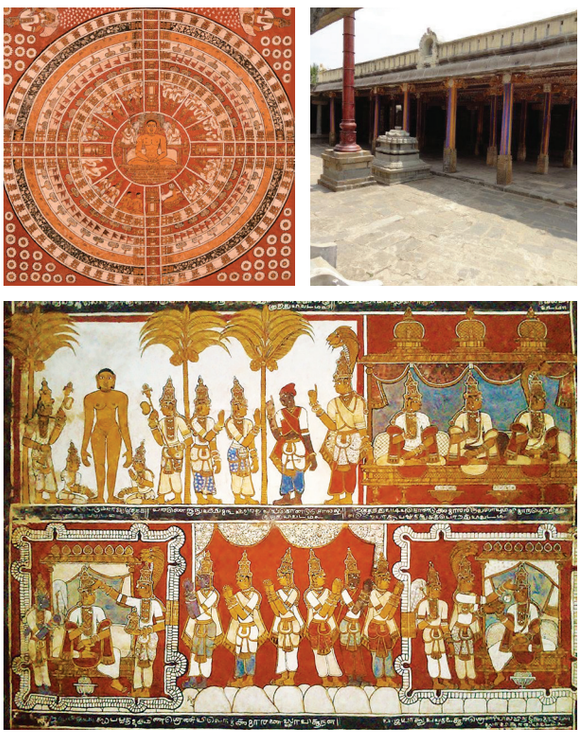
Non-Violence

The five vows are common to both the monks and lay followers. The monks were to observe the vows more rigorously than the lay followers. As Jainism placed great emphasis on non-violence, strict observers of the faith wear a muslin cloth around their mouth and nose so that they would not inhale small insects even by mistake. To avoid trampling on ants and other insects, Jain monks used feathers to sweep the path before walking. Jains could not practice agriculture or other crafts that involve killing or injury to living organisms. Hence they took to trading and money-lending and excelled in it. As a result, they were closely associated with urbanisation.

Jainism is an egalitarian religion. It does not sanction any inequality based on birth. It is one's deeds that determine one's status in society and not birth. Jainism believes that "by one's action one becomes a Brahmin, a Kshatriya, or a Vaishya, or a Sudra." Pride based on birth is considered a sin. Women were admitted into the monastic order. However, as a woman one cannot attain salvation. By accumulating merit by good deeds, a woman could be reborn as a man and then strive to attain salvation.

Jainism in Tamilnadu

Jainism spread to Tamil Nadu from about the third century CE. Jaina rock shelters are found in large numbers around Madurai and other places. The mention of death of Kopperuncholan by fasting in *Purananuru* is considered by some to be similar to Jaina practice of *sallekhana.* Jaina influence is strong in early Tamil literature. *Naladiyar*, *Palamoli*,



Jaina Kanchi, Tiruparuthikunram

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